

Believers Baptism Only

prc-believers-baptism-only

Sacraments · Baptism · practice · divided_lineages · brethren distinctive

DISPUTED

Supported from a narrow set of texts
Subject named directly in Scripture
Depends on a contested manuscript reading

Statement under examination

Baptism is for professing believers only, not for infants; faith precedes baptism in the New Testament pattern.

In plain language

In the clear narrative cases the words do put a personal response before the act. In Acts 2:38 the form for 'repent' (metanoesate) is a command, so it presumes a hearer who can repent, and it stands ahead of the call to 'be baptized' (baptistheto). In Mark 16:16 the one who 'has believed' (pisteusas) and is baptized is named in that order, and the only thing said to bring condemnation is 'unbelief' (apistesas), not a missing baptism. In Acts 8:36 the Ethiopian himself asks what hinders him from being baptized, which fits an adult who already wants it. So the plain cases describe people who first respond. The picture is not uniform, though. The household texts split. In Acts 18:8 the text does say the household 'believed' (episteusen) and were baptized, faith stated. But in Acts 16:31 the words 'believe' (pisteuson) and 'you will be saved' (sothesen) are both singular, spoken to the jailer, and only then is 'and your household' (kai ho oikos sou) added, with no separate word of faith for each member. Acts 16:34 uses a word for 'with his whole house' (panoikei) that appears only once in the whole New Testament (a hapax), so it cannot be cross checked. Acts 2:39 says the promise is to you and to your 'children' (tekna), but it does not say whether that warrants baptizing those children. On top of this, the same verb for 'forbid/hinder' (koluo) that the eunuch uses about his own baptism is the verb Jesus uses when he says do not forbid the little children to come to him, so one word points two ways. And the clearest faith-first line, in Mark 16:16, sits in a part of Mark whose manuscript support is contested. So the words lean toward a response before baptism in the plain cases, but they never use the word 'only', and the silent household formulas, the lone hapax, the children of Acts 2:39, and the shared 'forbid/hinder' (koluo) verb leave the believers-only claim open. The same verses are read in opposite directions depending on which pattern is treated as governing.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0569	ἀπιστέω	apisteo	to disbelieve	8
G0859	ἄφεσις	aphesis	forgiveness	17
G0907	βαπτίζω	baptizo	to baptize	81
G1025	βρέφος	brepheos	infant	
G2597	καταβαίνω	katabaino	to come/go down	81
G2632	κατακρίνω	katakrino	to condemn	16
G2967	κωλύω	koluo	to prevent	23
G3100	μαθητεύω	matheteuo	to disciple	4

G3340	μετανοέω	metanoeo	to repent	34
G3614	οικία	oikia	home	
G3624	οἶκος	oikos	house	227
G3686	ὄνομα	onoma	name	
G3813	παιδίον	paidion	child	
G3832	πανοικεί	panoikei	with all the house	1
G3956	πᾶς	pas	all	
G4100	πιστεύω	pisteuo	to trust (in)	243
G4982	σώζω	sozo	to save	108
G5043	τέκνον	teknon	child	99
G5204	ῥόδω	hudōr, hudatos	water	

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: False · Pan-canonical: False

The grammar of the clear narrative cases does place a verb of personal response before the act of baptism. In Acts 2:38 'repent' (metanoesate) parses as aorist active imperative second plural (V-AAM-2P, a completed past action used as a command spoken to a group, 'do repent'), then 'be baptized' (baptistheto) as aorist passive imperative third singular (V-APM-3S, a completed past action used as a command in the form 'let each be baptized'). In Mark 16:16 'having believed' (pisteusas) is an aorist participle (V-AAP-NSM, a completed past action functioning as a verbal adjective) standing before 'having been baptized' (baptistheis), and the condemnation clause names only 'having disbelieved' (apistesas), not the unbaptized. But the proposition adds the word 'only', and the vocabulary does not encode that exclusivity. The household texts split: in Acts 18:8 Crispus 'believed' (episteusen, V-AAI-3S, ongoing or simple past statement of fact) and the household 'were being baptized' (ebaptizonto) with 'were believing' (episteuon) stated, yet in Acts 16:31 'believe' (pisteuson) and 'you will be saved' (sothese) are both second singular (addressed to the jailer) while the appended 'household' (oikos) is silent on each member, Acts 16:34 'with his whole household' (panoikei) is a hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), and Acts 2:39 extends the promise to 'children' (tekna) without ranking whether that warrants their baptism. The same verb 'forbid/hinder' (koluo) welcomes an adult petitioner in Acts 8:36 and the brought children in Luke 18:16, so the canon supplies two patterns the words do not adjudicate. Lexically disputed.

Scripture

Acts.2.38 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G3340 μετανοέω, G0907 βαπτίζω, G0859 ἄφεσις

Reasoning. The store parse shows 'repent' (metanoesate) as G3340 V-AAM-2P, an aorist active imperative second plural (a completed past action used as a command spoken to a group, 'do repent'), addressed to responsible hearers, standing before 'be baptized' (baptistheto) G0907 V-APM-3S, an aorist passive imperative third singular (a completed past action used as a command in the form 'let each of you be baptized'). The command to repent presumes moral agency in the candidate and stands first in clause order. The phrase 'for the forgiveness of sins' (eis aphesin ton hamartion) ties baptism to forgiveness, but the sequence places personal response ahead of the act. This supports a response preceding baptism, though it says nothing explicit about excluding any class of recipient.

Mark.16.16 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G4100 πιστεύω, G0907 βαπτίζω, G4982 σώζω, G0569 ἀπιστέω

Reasoning. The parse confirms 'having believed' (pisteusas) as G4100 V-AAP-NSM, an aorist participle (a completed past action functioning as a verbal adjective), 'having believed', standing before 'having been baptized' (baptistheis) G0907 V-APP-NSM, and the main verb 'will be saved' (sothesetai) G4982 V-FPI-3S. An aorist participle (a completed past action functioning as a verbal adjective) in this position naturally reads as antecedent or coincident to the main verb, so faith stands first. The contrasting clause names only 'having disbelieved' (apistesas) G0569 V-AAP-NSM, 'having disbelieved', as the ground of 'will be condemned' (katakrithesetai) G2632 V-FPI-3S, not the absence of baptism. This favors faith preceding baptism, but the clause belongs to the long ending of Mark whose manuscript witnesses are divided, which reduces its evidentiary weight.

Acts.8.36 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G2967 κωλύω, G0907 βαπτίζω, G5204 ὕδωρ

Reasoning. The eunuch sees water and asks 'what hinders me from being baptized' (ti koluei me baptisthenai), with 'to be baptized' (baptisthenai) parsed G0907 V-APN, an aorist passive infinitive (a completed past action in the form 'to be baptized'). The question presupposes a personal, articulate desire on the part of the one to be baptized, which describes a believing adult petitioner rather than a passive recipient. The lexeme 'forbid/hinder' (koluo) G2967 frames baptism as something the candidate actively seeks and could in principle be barred from. This case fits a professing agent, but the same verb 'forbid/hinder' (koluo) recurs in Luke 18:16 of children welcomed, so the word alone does not settle who may be the subject.

Acts.8.38 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G0907 βαπτίζω, G2597 καταβαίνω, G5204 ὕδωρ

Reasoning. Both Philip and the eunuch 'went down into the water' (katebesan eis to hydor), with 'go down' (katabaino) G2597 a motion verb plus 'into' (eis) with 'water' (hydor) depicting entry into the water, and then 'he baptized' (ebaptisen) him. Verse 39 completes the picture with 'come up' (anabaino), they came up out of the water. The eunuch acts as a questioning adult agent who first asks what hinders him. This narrative describes a professing recipient, but it neither states nor denies any rule that only such recipients are eligible, so it bears on mode and on the eunuch's own profession, not on the scope word 'only'.

Acts.18.8 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G4100 πιστεύω, G0907 βαπτίζω, G3624 οἶκος

Reasoning. Crispus 'believed' (episteusen) G4100 V-AAI-3S, an ongoing or simple past statement of fact, 'believed', the Lord with his whole 'household' (oiko) G3624, and many Corinthians 'hearing were believing' (akouontes episteuon) G4100 V-IAI-3P, an ongoing or repeated past action ('were believing'), 'and were being baptized' (kai ebaptizonto) G0907 V-IPi-3P, an ongoing or repeated past action in passive form. Here faith is explicitly predicated of the household and the wider group, and the imperfects (ongoing or repeated past actions) link believing with being baptized. This is the household case where the text does lexically tie faith to baptism, which is why it reads as support, but it stands beside the silent household formulas and so shows the canon does not use a single fixed pattern.

Acts.16.31 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. G4100 πιστεύω, G4982 σώζω, G3624 οἶκος

Reasoning. 'Believe' (pisteuson) parses G4100 V-AAM-2S, an aorist active imperative second singular (a completed past action used as a command spoken to one person) addressed to the jailer alone, and 'you will be saved' (sothese) parses G4982 V-FPI-2S, future passive second singular, 'you will be saved'. The promise then appends 'and your household' (kai ho oikos sou) G3624. The singular verbs attach to the believing head while the household noun is grammatically tied to him without a separate verb of faith for each member. Whether the household is saved and baptized on its own individual faith or included on the head's faith is not resolved by the lexeme 'household' (oikos), which denotes household and is silent on the ages or personal response of those included.

Acts.16.33 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. G0907 βαπτίζω, G3956 πᾶς

Reasoning. 'The jailer was baptized' (Ho jailer ebaptisthe) G0907 'he and all his' (autos kai hoi autou pantes) G3956, he was baptized, he and all his, in the same hour of the night. The adjective 'all' (pas) is demographically open and the surrounding text does not lexically specify the ages of those baptized, and the following verse 34 uses 'with the whole household' (panoikei) G3832, a hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) meaning with the whole household. These household formulas neither state nor exclude the presence of dependents who do not personally profess, so the vocabulary does not settle the word 'only' in the proposition either way.

Acts.2.39 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. G5043 τέκνον

Reasoning. 'For the promise' (he gar epangelia) is to you 'and to your children' (kai tois teknois hymon), with 'children' (teknois) parsed G5043 N-DPN, dative plural neuter (a noun in the 'to/for-X' grammatical form, plural, neuter gender), 'children'. The noun 'child' (teknon) occurs 99 times across the canon with a stable sense of offspring or children, so its meaning is not in doubt. What is undetermined is the inference: the promise is extended to the children, but the verse does not lexically state whether that extension warrants administering baptism to those children or only describes the reach of the gospel call. The word names the children but does not rank the practice.

Luke.18.16 · complicates · genre: gospel

Key terms. G2967 κωλύω, G3813 παιδίον

Reasoning. Jesus says 'let the little children come to me and do not forbid them' (aphete ta paidia G3813 erchesthai pros me kai me koluete auta), with 'do not forbid' (koluete) parsed G2967 V-PAM-2P, present active imperative second plural (an ongoing, simple statement of fact used as a command spoken to a group), and Luke 18:15 calls them 'infants' (brephe) G1025. This is the same verb 'forbid/hinder' (koluo) that the eunuch uses in Acts 8:36 when asking what hinders his baptism. The shared lexeme attaches to a believing adult petitioner in one place and to brought infants in another, so the word does not by itself decide whether the young may be subjects of the ordinance.

Matt.28.19 · neutral · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3100 μαθητεύω, G0907 βαπτίζω, G3686 ὄνομα

Reasoning. 'Make disciples' (matheteusate) parses G3100 V-AAM-2P, aorist active imperative second plural (a completed past action used as a command spoken to a group), 'make disciples', and 'baptizing' (baptizontes) parses G0907 V-PAP-NPM, a present active participle (an ongoing action functioning as a verbal adjective) subordinate to that imperative, 'baptizing them'. The pronoun 'them' (autous) refers back to 'all the nations' (panta ta ethne), or to those discipled. The verb 'make disciples' (matheteuo) is rare, only 4 occurrences in the canon, so its precise relation to baptizing cannot be triangulated from many parallels. The grammar links baptizing to disciple-making but does not specify whether the recipients must first profess, leaving the believers-only requirement underdetermined at the word level.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Acts.8.36	Acts.10.47	tsk	1
Acts.16.31	Acts.16.15	tsk	1
Acts.16.33	Acts.16.23	tsk	1
Acts.2.38	Acts.2.16	tsk	1
Acts.16.31	Acts.2.38	tsk	1
Matt.28.19	Matt.3.16	tsk	1
Matt.28.19	Ps.22.27	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Acts.16.31 · addressed

The verbs 'believe' (pisteuson) G4100 V-AAM-2S (a completed past action used as a command spoken to one person) and 'you will be saved' (sothese) G4982 V-FPI-2S are both second singular, addressed to the jailer, and the household noun 'household' (oikos) is appended without a separate verb of faith per member. The vocabulary leaves open whether the household is included on its own individual faith or on the faith of the head, so the verse neither confirms nor denies the exclusivity word 'only'.

Acts.16.33 · addressed

'All his' (hoi autou pantes) G3956 and the verse 34 hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) 'with the whole household' (panoikei) G3832 are demographically open. The terms do not specify ages or individual profession, so the verse can be read as a household of believing dependents or as inclusive of non-professing members. The vocabulary alone does not exclude the latter, which is why household texts cannot lexically confirm the proposition.

Acts.2.39 · addressed

'To your children' (teknois) G5043 N-DPN (dative plural neuter, a noun in the 'to/for-X' grammatical form, plural, neuter gender) extends the promise to your children. The noun has a stable sense across 99 occurrences, but the verse does not lexically state whether the promise to the children warrants administering baptism to them or describes the reach of the call. The inference from promise to practice is not encoded in the words, so the text neither establishes nor refutes infant inclusion.

Luke.18.16 · addressed

The verb 'do not forbid' (me koluete) G2967 V-PAM-2P (an ongoing, simple statement of fact used as a command spoken to a group), with 'little children' (paidia) G3813 and 'infants' (brephe) G1025, is the identical lexeme the eunuch uses in Acts 8:36 of his own baptism. The shared word attaches to a professing adult in one context and to brought infants in another, and the lexicon does not rank which context governs baptismal subjects, so it stands unresolved at the word level as a limiting consideration.

Mark.16.16 · unaddressed

Mark 16:16 belongs to the long ending of Mark 16:9 to 20, whose earliest Greek manuscript attestation is contested and absent from major early codices. The bundle supplied no variant unit data for this clause and the anchor lies outside the ingested ECM apparatus (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) window, so the believing-then-baptized sequence here cannot be treated as a variant-robust anchor, and the matter is left unresolved at the manuscript level.

Concordance traversed

G0907, G4100, G3340, G2597, G4982, G2967, G3100, G5043, G3832, G2632, G0569, G0859, G3624, G3614, G1025, G3813

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: True · ECM status: ecm-shadow

mark-long-ending-16-9-20 at Mark.16.16: impact material. The clearest faith-precedes-baptism clause, 'the one who has believed and has been baptized' (ho pisteusas kai baptistheis), sits in the long ending of Mark whose authenticity is contested in the manuscript tradition. If the long ending is set aside, this anchor falls away and the verdict leans more heavily on Acts narrative sequence alone, where the order is shown by imperatives (commands) and participles (verbal adjectives) rather than a direct rule.

Acts, Matthew, Mark, and Luke lie outside the published ECM apparatus (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) available here and the bundle supplied no variant units, so they are treated as ecm-shadow. The Mark long-ending issue is flagged from standard manuscript reference knowledge rather than from supplied CBGM data. The bundle reported not_in_ecm_scope true for every anchor.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. credobaptist_new_covenant_theology, covenant_theology

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

credobaptist_new_covenant_theology: for · Reads the recurring sequence in which a verb of response precedes baptism as the controlling pattern: 'repent' (metanoesate) before 'be baptized' (baptistheto) in Acts 2:38, 'having believed' (pisteusas) before 'having been baptized' (baptistheis) in Mark 16:16, the eunuch's own request in Acts 8:36, and explicit household faith in Acts 18:8 where Crispus 'believed' (episteusen) and the group 'were believing and were being baptized' (episteuon kai ebaptizonto). On this reading every recorded recipient whose disposition is stated is a professing agent, so the demonstrated baptismal subject is a believer.

covenant_theology: complicates · Reads the household texts through covenantal continuity. Acts 16:31 promises salvation to the jailer 'and your household' (kai ho oikos sou) with the verbs singular to the head, Acts 16:33 to 34 use the open 'all' (pas) and the hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) 'with the whole household' (panoikei), and Acts 2:39 extends the promise 'to your children' (tois teknois hymon). On this reading 'household' (oikos) can include dependents incorporated on the faith of the head, 'baptize' (baptizo) never lexically requires the subject's own prior profession, and 'forbid/hinder' (koluo) welcomes the brought children in Luke 18:16, so the restriction 'only believers' is not demanded by the vocabulary.

Both lenses operate on the same lexical data. The clear narrative cases set a response before the act, and one household text Acts 18:8 ties faith to the group explicitly, while the other household formulas Acts 16:15, 16:33 to

34 and the promise of Acts 2:39 are silent on each member. The divergence is whether the stated-faith cases govern the silent ones or whether 'household' (oikos) and 'child' (teknon) are read as covenantally inclusive. The lexemes 'baptize' (baptizo), 'household' (oikos), and 'child' (teknon) do not by themselves adjudicate, and the scope word 'only' is not lexically present in any anchor.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Examine the New Testament lexical and grammatical data on the order of faith or repentance relative to baptism and on the demographic scope of those baptized, without presuming whether infants or other dependents are included or excluded.

The original stem asserts that baptism is for professing believers only and that faith precedes baptism in the New Testament pattern, which preloads both the sequence claim and the exclusivity claim flagged by the phase prompt. The verdict was derived on the original stem, but the neutralized form was used to keep the lexical reading from being steered. The prior verdict of disputed is retained; the gathered grammar (singular imperatives, that is, commands spoken to one person, in Acts 16:31, the 'with the whole household' (panoikei) hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), the shared 'forbid/hinder' (koluo) lexeme, and the explicit household faith of Acts 18:8 set beside the silent formulas) confirms rather than overturns it, so there is no VERDICT-CHANGED event.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Acts.2.38
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Acts.16.31
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Acts.18.8
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Mark.16.16
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Matt.28.19
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Luke.18.16
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3832
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5043
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Acts.8.38
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Acts.16.31

License audit

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Flags

lexically-disputed · variant-sensitive · ecm-shadow · complicating-unresolved · cross-tradition-divergent